



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: July 6, 2026	Entry: 1
Description	This entry documents a ransomware incident affecting a small U.S. healthcare clinic, where attackers used a phishing email to deploy ransomware that encrypted critical patient files and disrupted business operations. This falls under the Detection and Analysis phase, since it involves identifying what happened and how the attacker gained access.
Tool(s) used	none
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who: An organized group of unethical hackers known for targeting healthcare and transportation organizations caused the incident. • What: The attackers deployed ransomware that encrypted the clinic's critical files, including patient records, and left a ransom note demanding payment for the decryption key. • When: Tuesday morning at approximately 9:00 a.m. • Where: Within the health care clinic's internal computer network and systems.

	• Why: The incident happened because employees fell for a targeted phishing email containing a malicious attachment, which installed malware and allowed the attackers to gain network access.
Additional notes	This incident highlights how a single successful phishing attempt can lead to full-scale operational shutdown, especially in healthcare where data availability is critical to patient care. It raises the question of whether the clinic had employee phishing awareness training or email filtering in place, and whether backups existed to avoid paying the ransom.

Date: July 14, 2026	Entry: 2
Description	This entry documents the analysis of a suspicious file artifact linked to a phishing incident at a financial services company, using VirusTotal to determine maliciousness and identify indicators of compromise (IoCs) mapped to the Pyramid of Pain. This falls under Detection and Analysis, as it focuses on confirming the artifact's threat level before response actions are taken.
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who: The file was likely deployed by an actor associated with the FlagPro/Fragtor malware family, based on the popular threat label and vendor detections. • What: A file hash was analyzed and confirmed malicious, identified as a Trojan/Backdoor rather than ransomware as initially assumed, with nearly all security vendors flagging it under related threat names.

	• When: at 1:13 p.m., with the SOC alert triggered at 1:20 p.m. • Where: employee's computer within the financial services company's network. • Why: The employee opened a password-protected spreadsheet attachment from a phishing email, which executed the malicious payload once opened.
Additional notes	This activity was a good reminder not to assume the malware type from the scenario description alone. The ransom note pointed to ransomware, but VirusTotal classified the file as a Trojan/Backdoor (FlagPro), which suggests remote access was the actual goal rather than file encryption. Cross-checking detections against the scenario details felt like a useful habit to build early on.

Date: July 14, 2026	Entry: 3
Description	This entry documents the response to a phishing alert ticket (A-2703) at a financial services company, following the organization's phishing playbook to evaluate and escalate the incident. This falls under Containment, Eradication, and Recovery, since it involves deciding whether to escalate the alert to stop further impact.
Tool(s) used	Alert ticketing system, phishing playbook/flowchart
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who: An unknown external sender using the alias "Def Communications" and a suspicious .su domain email address.

	• What: A phishing email disguised as a job application was sent with a password-protected attachment containing a confirmed malicious file (previously verified via VirusTotal). • When: The email was sent on Wednesday, July 20, 2022 at 9:30:14 AM. • Where: The email was sent to the HR inbox (hr@inergy.com) at the organization. • Why: The attacker used a job application pretext to convince HR staff to open a password-protected attachment, bypassing basic security scanning.
Additional notes	The mismatched sender domain and grammatical errors were easy to spot once flagged, which made me think about how easily an untrained employee could miss these details when they're not actively looking for them. This reinforced why phishing awareness training matters just as much as technical detection tools.

Date: July 14, 2026	Entry: 4
Description	This entry reviews a final incident report from a data breach affecting a mid-sized retail company, focusing on the incident timeline, investigation findings, response actions, and future recommendations. This falls under Post-Incident Activity , as it involves reviewing lessons learned and recommendations after the incident was resolved.
Tool(s) used	None (report review)

The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who: An external attacker exploited a web application vulnerability, later contacting the company via email demanding cryptocurrency payment in exchange for not leaking the stolen data. • What: The attacker performed a forced browsing attack by manipulating order numbers in purchase confirmation URLs, gaining unauthorized access to roughly 50,000 customer PII and financial records. • When: The initial extortion email was received on December 22, 2022, with the full incident confirmed and investigated starting December 28, 2022. • Where: The breach occurred through the company's e-commerce web application, specifically its purchase confirmation page. • Why: The web application lacked proper access controls, allowing an authenticated-looking URL parameter (order number) to be modified to access other customers' data without authorization.
Additional notes	This report shows how dismissing an early warning sign delayed the response, and how a missing authorization check on a URL parameter led to a large-scale breach. The recommended fixes felt like they should have been baseline practices from the start.

Reflections/Notes: **Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?**

The VirusTotal artifact analysis was the most challenging, mainly because of the sheer volume of data (hundreds of contacted IPs and domains) and learning to distinguish meaningful indicators from benign infrastructure noise.

Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?

Yes, I now see incident response as a structured lifecycle rather than a single reactive step. I better understand how detection, containment, and post-incident review all connect and build on each other.

Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?

I enjoyed using VirusTotal the most, since it let me practically apply threat intelligence concepts and cross-reference multiple data points instead of relying on a single detection signal.